

Dealing with the unexpected

Dealing with the unexpected is part of the innovation challenge—in some ways the most important part, as unexpected challenges can prove life-threatening to an organization. From Henry Ford working on “a car for Everyman,” to the IT specialists who moved banking, insurance, and stock trading online from paper, or the revolution in the music and entertainment industry caused by Internet file sharing, new business models are constantly emerging. And in each case, established players were severely damaged because they responded too slowly, leaving the door open for new competitors, some of whom have become today’s major players. To combat this, innovation managers should always try to answer the following questions:

- How can you search at the edge of your organization’s radar for problems and opportunities?
- How can you make sure your message gets listened to and acted upon when something important occurs?
- How can you implement innovations that are totally different from anything you have done in the past?

TIP

RESEARCH CHALLENGES

Be aware of areas in which proposed innovations could help make your organization both more vulnerable and more resistant to outside challenges.



CHECKLIST PREPARING FOR CHALLENGES

YES NO

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| • Does the organization’s management create “stretch goals” that provide the direction but not the route for innovation? | ☐ | ☐ |
| • Do you actively explore the future, making use of tools and techniques like scenarios and foresight? | ☐ | ☐ |
| • Do you have the capacity to challenge your current position—do you think about how your business could be adversely affected? | ☐ | ☐ |
| • Do you have strategic decision-making and project selection mechanisms to deal with radical proposals? | ☐ | ☐ |
| • Do you have, and make, connections across your industry to provide your organization with fresh perspectives? | ☐ | ☐ |
| • Do you have alerting mechanisms to warn you about new trends? | ☐ | ☐ |